

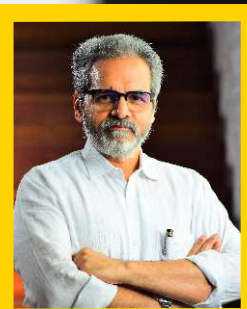
JANUARY '26

HEADLINE

Since 1956

NEWSLETTER OF THE ADVERTISING CLUB, MADRAS

THE FUTURE OF **ADVERTISING**



**FROM MERGERS TO MEDIA
EXPERTS RESPOND**



MESSAGE *from* PRESIDENT

Welcome to the second edition of Headline for the year.

This edition captures everything we've been up to over the past month and offers a glimpse of what's coming next. As we continue to evolve the newsletter, we're excited to spice things up by bringing in more of your voices, the topics you'd like to engage with, discuss, and learn from. After all, Headline is as much yours as it is the Club's.

With the start of the new year, we've also shifted gears with the launch of early bird entries for MADDYS 2026. We have a stellar jury planned that reflects our vision of giving due credit to creative excellence, whether it comes from a young, emerging agency or a seasoned one.

With multiple initiatives lined up by our talented Executive Committee, including PGDA, AdTalks, Adrenaline, Sparks, Brand & Brew, and more, I'm confident this year will truly live up to our core pillars of Inspire, Educate, and Engage.

We're always open to suggestions and look forward to your active participation in making this collaboration meaningful and impactful.



“

We have a stellar jury planned that reflects our vision of giving due credit to creative excellence

Warm regards,

Surej Salim

President,
Advertising Club of Madras

7th R K Swamy Memorial Lecture



The Madras Management Association (MMA) hosted the 7th R K Swamy Memorial Lecture in memory of R K Swamy, an iconic figure in Indian advertising and a multifaceted professional remembered for his contributions as an advertising leader, educator, philanthropist, and public-spirited individual.

The lecture was delivered by Sri Amitabh Kant, Governance Reformer and Public Policy Change Agent, and former CEO of NITI Aayog and India's Sherpa to the G20. Known for his progressive vision and strategic leadership, Sri Amitabh Kant addressed the theme "The Road to a \$30+ Trillion Economy by 2047."

Held on Friday, 12th December 2025, at the MMA Management Centre, Chennai, the lecture offered perspectives on India's long-term

economic growth, governance reforms, and policy frameworks shaping the nation's future.

The event was supported by the Advertising Club Madras. Mr. Surej Salim, President, Advertising Club Madras, delivered the vote of thanks, acknowledging the speaker and all those who contributed to the successful conduct of the lecture.



7th R K Swamy Memorial Lecture



Meet the Office Bearers
& Executive Committee Members

**WE'RE ALL
EARS!**

An ongoing initiative to meet our members and get valuable feedback on the club's activities. To know more details,
PLEASE CONTACT 044-42694778 / 8248717152

We would like you to contribute to our newsletter by submitting articles, book reviews, and job openings. We can also invite agencies, individuals to share/showcase their work. Please mail us to headline@adclubmadras.com

PRSI State Awards 2025 – Chennai Chapter



The PRSI State Awards 2025 – Chennai Chapter were held on 28th November 2025 at the Madras Management Association, Chennai, celebrating excellence in public relations, communication, branding and strategic storytelling. The awards, organised by the Public Relations Society of India (PRSI), Chennai Chapter, honoured outstanding achievements across a wide range of categories, recognising impactful campaigns, innovative communication strategies and professional excellence in the public relations field.

Nearly 115 awards were presented to organisations and professionals from the public sector, private corporates, MSMEs, creative agencies and individual practitioners whose work stood out for its effectiveness and creativity. The event also included a Lifetime Achievement Award presented to a distinguished member of the PR community in recognition of sustained contributions to the profession.

The Advertising Club Madras participated as the Community Partner for the event, underscoring its support for initiatives that recognise and encourage excellence in communication and public relations.



THE FUTURE OF ADVERTISING

FROM MERGERS TO MEDIA, EXPERTS RESPOND

The Counter-Trend

As holding companies continue to grow larger, a fascinating counter-narrative emerged in 2025. Two of the world's most renowned digital innovation agencies, R/GA and Huge, were acquired from IPG by private equity firms. After years of being part of a network, they are now effectively 'Independents' again.



Just as the giants merged, these iconic shops went their separate ways. Is this a signal that the 'Network Model' is failing creativity? Are we entering an era where 'Boutique Scale' is more valuable to clients than 'Global Scale'?



As holding companies continue to grow larger, a fascinating counter-narrative emerged in 2025. Two of the world's most renowned digital innovation agencies, R/GA and Huge, were acquired from IPG by private equity firms. After years of being part of a network, they are now effectively 'Independents' again.

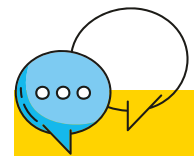
Just as the giants merged, these iconic shops went their separate ways. Is this a signal that the 'Network Model' is failing creativity? Are we entering an era where 'Boutique Scale' is more valuable to clients than 'Global Scale'?

Independent Creative shops are as old as advertising itself. It's not at all a new phenomenon. Some of the most well-known agency brands that we know of in a network portfolio, started their life as an independent creative shop.

Independents and Network brands have co-existed for a very long time and stellar creative work that built long term value for brands have come out of both the stables.

Some of the most memorable campaigns across the World and some of the most awarded campaigns at Cannes, have been created by Network Agency brands and Independents alike. So, it would be wrong to jump to the conclusion that it is now the age of the 'Independents' or that 'Network Model' is failing Creativity.

What fails Creativity is the lack of imagination and myopic vision of a lot of clients out there. Great creative work requires a great client who can recognize it from a distance, give it the right shape, protect it from being ruined by those who do not understand it and



Creativity is not stifled by the environment it is born in. It is killed by those who do not understand it.



help the idea see the light of the day and be known to the world outside. Creativity is not stifled by the environment it is born in. It is killed by those who do not understand it.

Boutiques and Networks have their own strengths and weaknesses. It requires a very nuanced perspective to ascertain whether Boutique Scale or Network Scale is right for a brand and that depends entirely on a unique set of parameters that are relevant for the brand, consumer and medium.

— **Mr. Hari Krishnan** -
Chief Growth Officer - FCB India



Moves like R/GA and Huge stepping out of IPG into PE-backed independence signal dissatisfaction with legacy structures, not with scale itself - both have independently expressed dissatisfaction with complex agency structures.

Clients increasingly want specialized talent, faster decision making and agility without giving up global reach, compliance and integration. This is driving hybrid models, for instance, clients look at holding companies for certain kinds of mandates (for instance corporate communications, media buying etc.) while they opt for boutique partners for specialist needs (for example SEO, Influencer Marketing etc.). The next era is less “networks vs boutiques” and more: which partner can combine distinctive creative POV, technology fluency and operating agility while staying compliant and having the ability to scale.



R/GA and Huge leaving IPG for PE-backed independence reflect dissatisfaction with legacy structures, not scale.



— **Ms. Kavitha Ganesan**,
Head of Marketing,
TVS Srichakra Limited



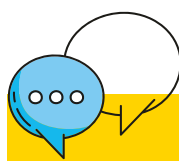
The renewed interest in boutique and independent agencies reflects the increasing diversity of marketing needs rather than any failure of the network model. Large agency networks continue to play an important role in offering scale, process strength and the ability to manage complex, multi-market campaigns. For many brands, this stability and long-term brand stewardship remains extremely valuable.

At the same time, boutique agencies often bring sharper cultural insight, strong platform understanding and the ability to move quickly with new formats and ideas. Their structures allow faster experimentation, which is especially useful in social, influencer and performance-driven environments.

As a result, many advertisers are now working with blended agency models. Network agencies may lead core strategy and large-scale

execution, while specialist agencies support specific business objectives such as regional storytelling or performance marketing. This allows brands to balance consistency with agility.

Rather than one model replacing the other, what we are seeing is a more collaborative ecosystem where different partners play different roles. Success today depends less on size and more on how well agencies align with business goals, work alongside other partners and deliver measurable impact.



Many advertisers now use blended models: networks drive strategy and scale, specialists handle regional storytelling and performance marketing.



— Mr. Srinivasan,
Managing Director, Vikatan Group

The consolidation of Omnicom & IPG

Late last year, the industry witnessed perhaps its most historic consolidation when Omnicom completed its acquisition of IPG. In India, this brings competitors like DDB Mudra, MullenLowe Lintas, and FCB under the same ultimate parent company.



For a consumer (Marketer) in India, does this consolidation limit his choice of partners due to conflict-of-interest, or does it actually make life easier by giving him access to a deeper, unified talent pool under one roof?



The question of whether consolidation of agencies triggers conflict of interest concerns or offers access to larger pool of talent is an age-old one, captured succinctly in the meme that serving two competing clients is conflict, but more than 3 is expertise.

But I submit that this is missing the woods for the trees. And we only need to look to nature for the answers. Evolution and progress is always about divergence, not convergence. When agencies merge, if the leaders were going to focus on taking



the best traits from all the members and find ways to cross-pollinate, this would be good for everyone.

Sadly, we know that most such mergers are mostly about cutting costs, trimming talent and flattening any signs of divergent thinking, driven by investment bankers advising owners and shareholders on squeezing stone for blood, as it were. Slippery slope to mediocrity, inevitably.

In sum, I wouldn't worry about conflict, but I would also not be enthused that a wider pool of talent is suddenly going to enrich the work of the industry. I would worry that the quality of work overall would only disintegrate even more.

Number-chasing programmatic work bereft of insight and soulless ai-based creative work are busy digging the grave, and corporate lawyers are



Agency consolidation often prioritizes cost-cutting over genuine cross-pollination of talent, risking mediocrity



— **Mr. Karthi Marshan** -
Principal - Marshan.ink

Consolidation is a positive and necessary evolution for the Indian media and marketing ecosystem. In a diverse and rapidly growing market like India, mergers and acquisitions provide organizations with the scale, capital, and capabilities required to unlock their full growth potential. When strong institutions come together, it allows for deeper investments in regional content, technology, data, and distribution — areas that are critical to serving India's varied audiences.



When executed with clarity and responsibility, consolidation does not limit choice; instead, it strengthens products, enhances credibility, and delivers greater value to consumers while enabling brands and media organizations to scale sustainably in India's dynamic market.

— **Mr. Adimoolam**,
Director & Publisher, Dinamalar

From a business perspective, consolidation brings efficiency, resilience, and the ability to innovate faster in a highly competitive environment. From a consumer, reader, and viewer standpoint, it translates into richer content, better storytelling, wider reach across languages and geographies, and more seamless experiences across platforms.



Consolidation brings efficiency, resilience, and the ability to innovate faster in a highly competitive environment.





The Omnicom and IPG consolidation redefines agency dynamics globally, and India is no exception. For marketers, in my opinion, it's not so much about losing choice: what would be critical would be how intelligently the holding company manages autonomy and specialization across its network.

Historically, large holding firms have thrived because they nurture diverse agency cultures under one umbrella—each with its own DNA, leadership, and client base. If Omnicom preserves the individuality of networks like DDB Mudra, Lintas, and FCB while fostering shared access to data, technology, and talent, clients stand to benefit from the best of both worlds.

Today, Marketing leaders are looking at more integrated brand thinking and seamless marketing. For instance, even within a single agency - client relationship, we have seen a new way of working in the post pandemic era, where our agency partners offer us a team based on capability and talent that is required for our brand from across locations and offices rather than the legacy way of working where clients had to stick to one agency office. Hence rather than restricting choice, this consolidation could enable a new era —where



The shift isn't from choice to constraint, but from choice to synergy, creating a future-ready partner ecosystem for India's consumer landscape.

boundaries blur between creative, media, and data-led disciplines to deliver sharper, integrated thinking. If managed well, the combined entity has the potential to give clients access to broader capabilities, richer consumer insights, and a more seamless execution framework across touchpoints.

From a conflict-of-interest standpoint, clients in India are smart enough to demand clear firewalls and bespoke teams. What will matter most is transparency in governance and the ability to maintain differentiated value propositions.

In essence, this merger could move the conversation from "choice" to "synergy". Clients won't necessarily lose options; they may gain a more integrated, future-ready partner ecosystem that's better equipped to handle India's ever-changing, complex consumer landscape.



— Ms. Kavitha Ganesan,
Head of Marketing,
TVS Srichakra Limited



From an Indian advertiser's point of view, consolidation reflects how the marketing ecosystem is evolving, with greater need for scale, integration and specialised capabilities working together. Large agency networks today bring multiple services under one umbrella, from creative and media to data,

technology, commerce and regional execution. For brands operating across markets and platforms, this can make coordination easier and help deliver more consistent brand thinking across touchpoints.

At the same time, advertisers are naturally mindful of conflict of interest, especially in competitive categories. Trust and confidentiality remain non-

negotiable. Global networks are aware of this and typically put strong governance and team separation in place. In sensitive categories, advertisers may still choose partners carefully based on how comfortable they are with these structures.

It is also important to note that consolidation at the holding company should not reduce real choice in the market. When AI is enabling clients to create their own content, creatives work with influencers and reach audiences independent of agencies, it's house sound a firm warning to the agency business - Adapt or perish. India continues to see strong growth in independent and specialist agencies, particularly in

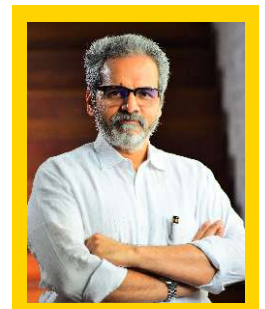


Consolidation provides coordinated access to creative, media, data, and regional capabilities.

performance marketing, influencer ecosystems, regional content and platform-native storytelling. Many advertisers today work with multiple partners, selecting agencies based on specific objectives rather than expecting one agency to do everything.

So while consolidation can simplify access to integrated capabilities, it does not limit options. If anything, brands now have more flexibility to build partner ecosystems that combine scale, specialisation and local relevance, depending on what the business needs at any given stage.

— Mr. Srinivasan,
Managing Director, Vikatan Group



Publicis Groupe acquiring 'Influential'

Influencer marketing has often been likened to the 'wild west'—a relationship-based approach that can be challenging to measure.

But Publicis Groupe's move to acquire 'Influential' and plug it directly into their Epsilon data engine suggests a shift. They are effectively industrialising the creator economy.

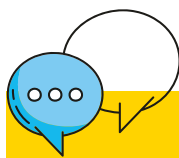




Does this move signal the end of the 'organic' influencer collaboration? In 2026, will creators simply be treated as another programmatic inventory slot, bought and sold purely on data rather than content?



Two things will happen this year. One the influencer segment will become undifferentiated at the lower end. The whole influencer at mass end offers no big advantage to the brands. At the upper end the partnership with the big Influencers will start to become important. The influencers would want greater stability and will not want to be firing all cylinders for all brands that come their way. The big tech brands today look at them as a short term reach medium, they will change it and start to build long term partnership that keeps the big ones in the brand camp. The real challenge to this will come from AI influencers. That is a rapidly rising segment and no one knows where this will go. I see brands creating their own AI influencers and walking away from real ones.



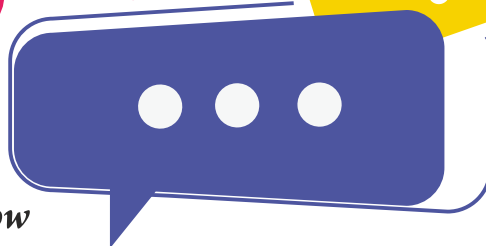
Low-end influencers will become undifferentiated; big influencer partnerships will grow in importance.



— Mr. Naresh Gupta -
Co-founder and CSO -
Bang in the Middle

Reliance Jio + Disney Star (JioStar)

The operational merger of Reliance's media assets with Disney Star to form 'JioStar' has fundamentally rewritten the Indian media playbook. We are looking at a single entity that now controls the vast majority of sports rights (IPL, BCCI, ICC) and premium entertainment across both TV and OTT.



For media planners and buyers, has the era of 'negotiation' ended? Are we moving into a 'Rate Card Reality' where the publisher holds all the cards?



While the JioStar consolidation is a landmark moment for India's media ecosystem, it doesn't necessarily mean the end of negotiation—it simply changes its nature. If the new entity were to operate purely on monopolistic terms, relying on rigid rate cards, it risks narrowing its advertiser base to only those with deep pockets. The long-term success of such a platform depends not on owning content, but on sustaining advertiser diversity and ecosystem trust.

Brands today are increasingly outcome-oriented and cost-conscious. If access to premium properties like IPL or flagship entertainment becomes prohibitively expensive, many advertisers—especially challenger brands and

regional players—will recalibrate towards more efficient avenues: emerging sports including football, women's cricket and regional leagues, influencer ecosystems, connected TV, and digital-first entertainment formats that deliver sharper targeting at lower cost. JioStar will be smart if they do not capitalize on their monopoly by playing on rates, rather they should focus on the flexibility they can offer advertisers with their scale: develop dynamic products, audience led deals and low entry packages.

— Ms. Kavitha Ganesan,
Head of Marketing,
TVS Srichakra Limited



JioStar should leverage its scale for flexible, audience-led products and low-entry packages, not monopoly pricing.



The creation of JioStar is a major shift, bringing premium sports and entertainment content together with massive audience reach. Naturally, high-demand properties, especially sports, are driven more by content value and viewer demand than by volume-led price negotiations.

That said, it would be incorrect to say that negotiation has ended. What has changed is the nature of the conversation. Media buying today is less about spot rates alone and more about the overall value of partnerships. Advertisers are increasingly discussing long-term associations, content integrations, cross-platform packages and outcome-based solutions.

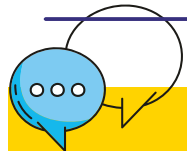
For media owners, this opens up opportunities to offer more holistic propositions. For advertisers,

it allows them to look beyond individual properties and build stronger brand presence across content ecosystems.

So while premium inventory will always command premium pricing, the market is not moving into a fixed rate card environment. Commercial discussions will continue, but they will be shaped more by strategic value and performance expectations rather than only by rate comparisons.

In that sense, the focus is shifting from buying space to building partnerships that deliver business outcomes.

— Mr. Srinivasan,
Managing Director, Vikatan Group



Advertisers are increasingly discussing long-term associations, content integrations, cross-platform packages, and outcome-based solutions.

With one entity owning both the biggest TV channels and the biggest OTT platforms, are we finally going to see the death of the 'TV vs. Digital' budget war? Will ad spends become platform-agnostic in 2026?

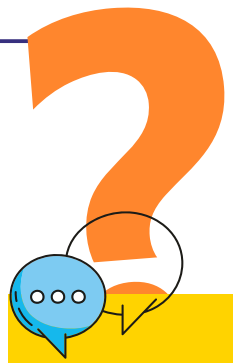


We are already seeing a huge shift in the TV vs Digital budget war and this is a welcome change for advertisers. Screen-agnostic omnichannel planning and cross platform deals will be the future. However, ad spends will not suddenly become fully platform-agnostic in 2026, we will see the transition happening slowly.

With one media house controlling major TV and OTT assets, marketers will look for total reach and yield across screens, media planners will push for unified frequency capping, de-duplicated reach, and cross-screen packages, treating TV and OTT as one pool, and this will help in executing integrated marketing campaigns in the true sense of the word.

However, TV and digital still play distinct roles in the funnel and measurement for both mediums will continue to happen differently for instance CPRP/CPM for TV/OTT. Outcome metrics (incremental reach, CTV households) will matter more than the old “share between TV and digital” debate, especially as CTV grows its share of professional video ad spend. It will be important for client organization structures to adapt to the new normal to avoid any budget and priority tensions that may hamper platform-agnostic thinking.

— **Ms. Kavitha Ganesan,**
Head of Marketing,
TVS Srichakra Limited



Screen-agnostic, omnichannel planning and cross-platform deals are the future, though the transition will be gradual in 2026.



Having the same organisation own both large TV networks and leading OTT platforms certainly creates the right conditions to move away from rigid platform-based planning. When the same content and audiences flow across screens, it makes more sense to plan around viewing behaviour, content environments and engagement rather than the device alone.

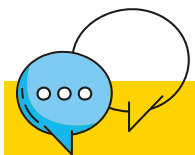
However, budgets are also influenced by how brands are internally structured, how performance is measured and how accountability is assigned between teams. These systems still treat television and digital differently in many organisations, so

a complete shift to fully platform-agnostic budgeting may take time.

That said, by 2026, we are likely to see more unified planning approaches, where campaigns are built around content properties, audience segments and consumption moments, with TV and digital working together as part of a single media idea.

This can lead to better creative consistency and more efficient use of budgets. But the real shift will depend not only on ownership structures, but also on how well measurement frameworks and planning tools evolve to reflect how consumers actually consume content across screens.

— **Mr. Srinivasan,**
Managing Director, Vikatan Group



Ownership of TV and OTT enables campaigns built around content, audiences, and consumption moments rather than devices.

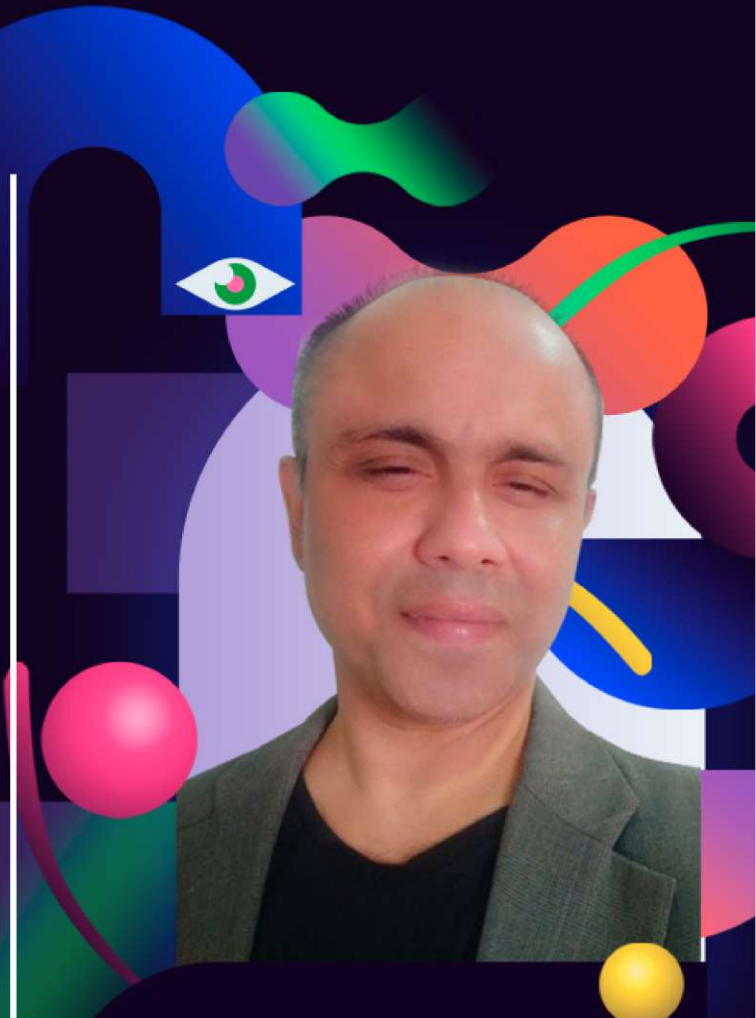
Part 2

USA & CANADA GLOBAL DESI DIASPORA MARKET

ONE OF THE MOST
SUCCESSFUL DIASPORA
COMMUNITIES WORLDWIDE

Dr Tausif Malik

Publisher & Editor of the Desi Buzz, The MAD Buzz
The Dubai Buzz, GCC Startup News
Startup Berita & RiseBack & Founder of RiseBack.org



The 32nd session of the InsightView Series continued its exploration of the Global Desi Diaspora Market with Part Two focusing on the USA and Canada. The session was led by Dr. Tausif Malik, Publisher & Editor of The Desi Buzz, The MAD BUZZ, The Dubai Buzz, GCC Startup News, and Startup Berita, and Founder of RiseBack.org. A social entrepreneur, media innovator, and educator, Dr. Malik brought deep regional insights and a global perspective to the discussion.

Held on Thursday, 18th December, from 4 PM to 5 PM via Zoom, the session examined the scale, diversity, and influence of the Desi diaspora across North America. Dr. Malik highlighted the cultural dynamics, consumption patterns, and media behaviours of Indian-origin communities in the USA

and Canada, emphasizing how these markets differ while remaining deeply connected to their roots.

The discussion offered valuable takeaways for brands and marketers seeking to engage this audience through culturally relevant storytelling, digital-first strategies, and community-led communication. Insights into diaspora-driven entrepreneurship, evolving media ecosystems, and cross-border brand opportunities further enriched the session.

The session provided participants with a nuanced understanding of the North American Desi diaspora and its growing strategic importance for advertisers, marketers, and communication professionals.

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